

| 1981 | INFOSYS IS FORMED

Knowledge Warriors

A group of Indian engineers create a world-class company to ride the IT boom

Imagine a 28-year-old French-speaking computer geek sleeping without food on a railway platform in a border town between Serbia and Bulgaria, who is then bundled by the police into a tiny cell and made to starve for the next 72 hours. Later, he is dragged and thrown into a guard's compartment for a 20-hour-journey to Istanbul. The man, Nagavara Ramarao Narayana Murthy, 63, remembers the 1974 humiliation at the hands of the Bulgarian police, who, based on a fellow train passenger's baseless complaint, subjected him to a raw deal. Seven years later, backed by wife Sudha Kulkarni's encouragement, he found himself working for the Pune-based tech company Patni Computers. But Murthy, a Mysore University electrical engineer, realised that a tech company of his own was the only way forward to shake off his Bulgarian nightmare. He brainstormed the idea of starting a company with his colleagues—N.S. Raghavan, Nandan Nilekani, Kris Gopalakrishnan, K. Dinesh, Ashok Arora and S.D. Shibulal—and Infosys was born on July 2, 1981. The company had two American clients to start with. Gopalakrishnan, currently the CEO of the world's second largest \$4 billion IT behemoth, was at that time spearheading marketing operations in the US. Murthy, now the chairman of Infosys, played captain, coaching and encouraging his colleagues. He recalls how he had to convince the other founders not to sell their company for \$1 million to an American company in 1990, even though the business was not satisfactory. Patience paid off and in 1991, Infosys became the first Indian company to be listed on Nasdaq, making its employees shareholders. Today, Infosys boasts of a market cap which is 30,000 times higher. In 1993 when Infosys went public and its IPO was undersubscribed, an American Investment bank, Morgan Stanley, bailed it out by picking up 13 per cent equity at Rs 95 a share. Share prices soon rocketed to Rs 8,100 by 1999, making it the costliest share in the market at the time. Currently, Infosys boasts of over a lakh employees worldwide

with offices in more than 20 countries. Infosys achievements have not been limited to the corporate sector alone. In September 2009, Sonia Gandhi inaugurated one of India's largest educational and training centres to be run by the company at its 337-acre campus in Mysore. As the Infosys chairman puts it: "I believe we all have at some time or the other eaten fruits from the trees that we did not plant. It is our time now to plant trees for future generations. It is our sacred responsibility."

ALSO

- Bhaskara-II is launched from Kapustin Yar in Russia
- IMF announces a Rs 5,000 crore loan to India, the highest in the fund's history
- 308 people die of drinking illicit liquor in Bangalore



NILEKANI (LEFT)
WITH MURTHY IN
BANGALORE

THE MAIN EVENT

Rajiv Gandhi Joins Politics

For the majority of Congress(I) leaders, it was the season for out-singing each other with paeans of praise to Rajiv. Said Patil: "Rajiv's formal entry into politics will mark a turning point in history." Mused Tariq Anwar, member of Parliament and Youth Congress(I) general secretary: "Rajivji's induction into politics is a victory for the youth." Though laced with cynicism, the reactions of some of the sober elements in the opposition betrayed a spirit of acceptance.

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PRANOD PISHANAKA, www.indiatoday.com

by Stephen David

Harshad Mehta Scam
A rise was engineered in the stock exchanges in the Rs 600-crore scam in 1992.

Ramar Pillai Claimed
to have invented herbal fuel, which was actually kerosene-laced water in 1996.

Fodder Scam Exposed
the nexus between bureaucrats, businessmen and politicians in Bihar in 1996.

Chandraswami The
self-styled godman is accused of cheating Lakhubhai Pathak of \$100,000 in 1996.

Abdul Karim Telgi Scam
A fake stamp racket involving Rs 23,000 crore was busted in 1999.